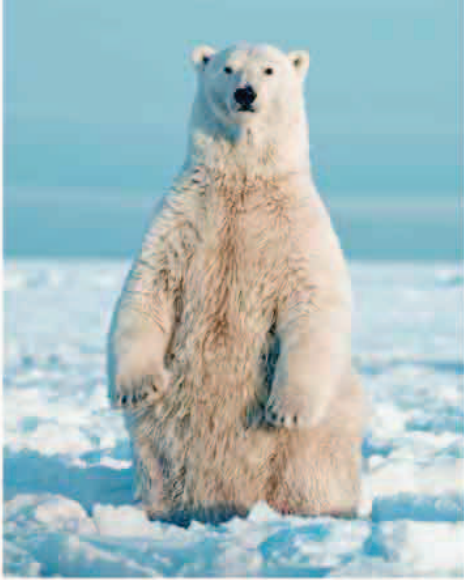




SEA BEAR

The polar bear is a meat-eater that hunts at sea on the winter pack ice, protected from the cold by its dense fur and a thick layer of fat under its skin. Although polar bears can swim well, they cannot hunt in the water. When the sea ice melts in summer, they must stay ashore without eating until the sea freezes once again.

SNOW CUBS

Each female polar bear usually has two cubs. They are born in autumn in a snow den on land. The mother feeds her tiny cubs on her milk throughout the winter, then leads them on to the sea ice in early spring in search of prey. The cubs stay with their mother until they are about two years old.

ICE HUNTER

Polar bears eat seals—especially ringed seals that breed in isolated snow caves on the floating pack ice. The bears locate these hidden seal nurseries by smell, and are able to detect them from at least 0.6 miles (a kilometer) away. When a bear finds a seal nursery, it uses its weight to punch down through the snow and seize the seal before it can escape—killing it with a single swipe of its huge paw.



◀ FAMILY MEAL

Polar bears roam the drifting pack ice in search of prey. The cubs follow their mother so that they can learn how to hunt for themselves.

